be done (discussed under the forthcoming sub-title ‘Improving Primary Education’), see Box 2.8).

NEED OF FORMAL APPRENTICESHIPS

In the process of achieving a quality manpower, experts have always emphasised the schemes which impart formal apprenticeships to the working population of a country. Though India has already such schemes put in place, but due to several reasons could not bring in the desired effects in the economy. As India aspires for higher demographic dividend, it is high time that India re-oriented and restructured the existing set of Acts and Rules governing the apprenticeships to bring in rational points, we may have a **three part** discussion on the issue.

1. The Importance of Apprenticeship

Equipping the labur force with productive skills lies at the heart of tapping the demographic dividend. Apprenticeships are an effective way of ensuring that entry-level workers have the skills required to join the formal workforce by ‘learning on the job’ and even ‘earning while learning’. It has been amongst the oldest social institutions in India. However, it needs to be formalised and scaled up. In the current environment, India’s educational system is overburdened by sheer demand for quality education. According to a recent study[44] by India’s first vocational university, 80 per cent of India’s higher education system of 2030 is yet to be built and is grappling with the *threefold problem* of cost, quality, and scale. This is compounded by the inability of much of the current education system to produce ‘work-ready’ labour. In fact, the **disconnect** between the formal educational system and requirements of the employers becomes even more acute in times of rapid structural and technological change. In such an environment, company-led apprenticeship programmes, that place employers at the heart of education, can play a powerful role in imparting job-relevant skills and also repairing, preparing, and upgrading the labour force. They can aid five important transitions that the labour force is currently making

i. from agriculture to non-agriculture,